

A black and white photograph of George Attla, a musher, leading a team of sled dogs. He is wearing a headband, sunglasses, and a jacket, and is holding the sled's handle. The dogs are running on a snowy or icy surface. In the background, a crowd of spectators is visible, some standing and some walking. The scene appears to be a sled dog race or competition.

GEORGE ATTLA

Class of 2007 (b. Aug. 8, 1933)

Closing in on the 1972 Fur Rondy crown in dominating fashion.

Highlights

- *Ten-time Fur Rondy Champion*
- *Nine International Sled Dog Association Unlimited Class medals*
- *Eight-time North American Open Champion*

His childhood battle with tuberculosis resulting in a fused right kneecap meant he couldn't run beside his sled to keep up with his competitors, so George Attla out-trained them and out-thought them.

His indomitable determination to win meant that the man known as "The Huslia Hustler" for the Athabaskan village that nurtured him, and for his methods on the trail, became a legend in his own time.

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George Attla was unique. Born in 1933, Attla came of age in the 1950s when the biggest events in dog mushing were the sprint racing championships at the Anchorage Fur Rendezvous and the North American Open in Fairbanks.

As is still true today, it was mighty expensive and logistically tricky to transport a prized dog team from a village located off the road system to one of the Territory's population hubs. In an era when there was no satellite television, limited air service, and residents of remote villages depended on one another in a subsistence lifestyle patterned after centuries of coping with the harsh Arctic climate, villagers pooled resources.

They formed one team with the best dogs normally used for trotting along trap-lines, fetching wood and water, and for transportation between communities.

Attla was 10 when his father George Sr. gave him his first two dogs and dog mushing became Attla's salvation. He admittedly lived with a chip on his shoulder after spending lonely years away from home in a Native hospital in Southeast Alaska recuperating from his illness and was groping for an identity.

In February of 1958 he felt prepared to take on the best mushers in the world in Anchorage over three heats of 20-or-so miles spread over three days. Financed and encouraged by brother Steven, who also loaned him dogs, his parents, and esteemed elder Sidney Huntington, Attla headed to the big city two weeks ahead of time.

The Fur Rendezvous was a winter carnival, created to relieve cabin fever

during Alaska's long, dark winter, a party that did its best to pretend that winter didn't exist, or at least could be temporarily tamed. It would be easy to become distracted by the fur auctions, the bar-hopping and the swirl of the crowds, but although nervous, Attla focused on his business. The centerpiece of the show

was the world championship dog races and thousands of fans crammed Fourth Avenue in downtown Anchorage, leaning against temporary fencing, shouting support for past winners and good friends. The Rondo was just about the biggest sporting event on the calendar and it was broadcast live on the radio throughout the Great Land.

In the same manner that the nation was riveted to Joe Louis heavyweight title fights, Alaska ears tuned in to reports of the Rondo, even in far off Bush communities.

Attla, his jet black hair, angular frame and youthful face, stepped into the scene as a 25-year-old unknown. Among the formidable contenders was Gareth Wright, a Fairbanks-area musher developing his own breed of husky, and who would also sire a mushing dynasty among humans with his children and grandchildren.

Three days into his Rondo racing career, the previously anonymous Attla was the toast of the mushing world. His victory sent his family into a delirium. Attla's mother Eliza fell asleep during the radio broadcast, but his father was an attentive listener. When Attla crossed the finish-line first on the third day to earn the crown, his dad jumped up and down and began screaming at his mom, "George won! George won!"

Attla's triumph signaled more than that. The victory triggered a new era of



"The Huslia Hustler" became an Alaskan sports icon.

GEORGE ATTLA

excitement for Alaska sprint mushing. Attla's win marked the beginning of a period of unprecedented fierce competition, dominating personalities and thrilling races. For Attla, the victory decided his life's direction. He was still a comparative novice, but he was in the game to stay.

He was also very proud of what he had accomplished.

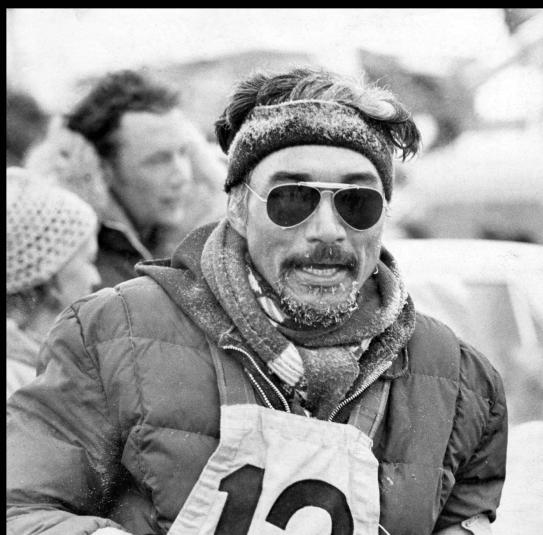
"I was the world's championship dog musher," Attla said. "And there were a lot of people there to see it. I can hardly describe the way it felt."

In the ensuing years, even as he grayed and aged the way all athletes do, Attla acquired the savvy for the trail and the know-how in breeding dogs to become the greatest sprint musher of all time. As is common in other sports, Attla also had a foil, or chief rival, to bring out the best in him and to further energize fans. Attla's main competition, his equal for a time, was Dr. Roland Lombard, a veterinarian from Wayland, Massachusetts, who never lived in Alaska but who in the late 1950s made regular winter pilgrimages to the North Country.

This was the Muhammad Ali-Joe Frazier rivalry of mushing — an analogy that Attla, a boxing fan, would enjoy. Attla and Lombard were two heavyweights slugging it out on the snowy trails on the outskirts of Anchorage and Fairbanks. Both friendly men, but slightly cocky about their mushing prowess, it was a publicly convivial series of showdowns that stretched into the mid-1970s, when Lombard retired.

By then Lombard owned eight Rondo titles and six North American crowns. The difference was that Attla did not go away. He persevered, adapting to the encroachments of age and the aches that come with bouncing along the trail and collected 10 Fur Rendezvous championships and eight North Americans.

These were more than minor bruises. Attla tore off the tip of his right pinky finger at one point and by the early 1970s he was blind in one eye, despite two operations that failed to cure his glaucoma. None of that drove him into retirement, however.



Attla retired as the greatest sprint musher of all time.

When the 1,100-mile Iditarod Trail Sled Dog Race began in 1973, Attla was one of the first mushers on the trail. At the time more of an extended camping trip than an all-out race because no one knew if the dogs could run that far, few envisioned that the Iditarod would become the most famous mushing event in the world and that sled dogs would become famous as long-distance running animals. Attla finished fifth in the inaugural run.

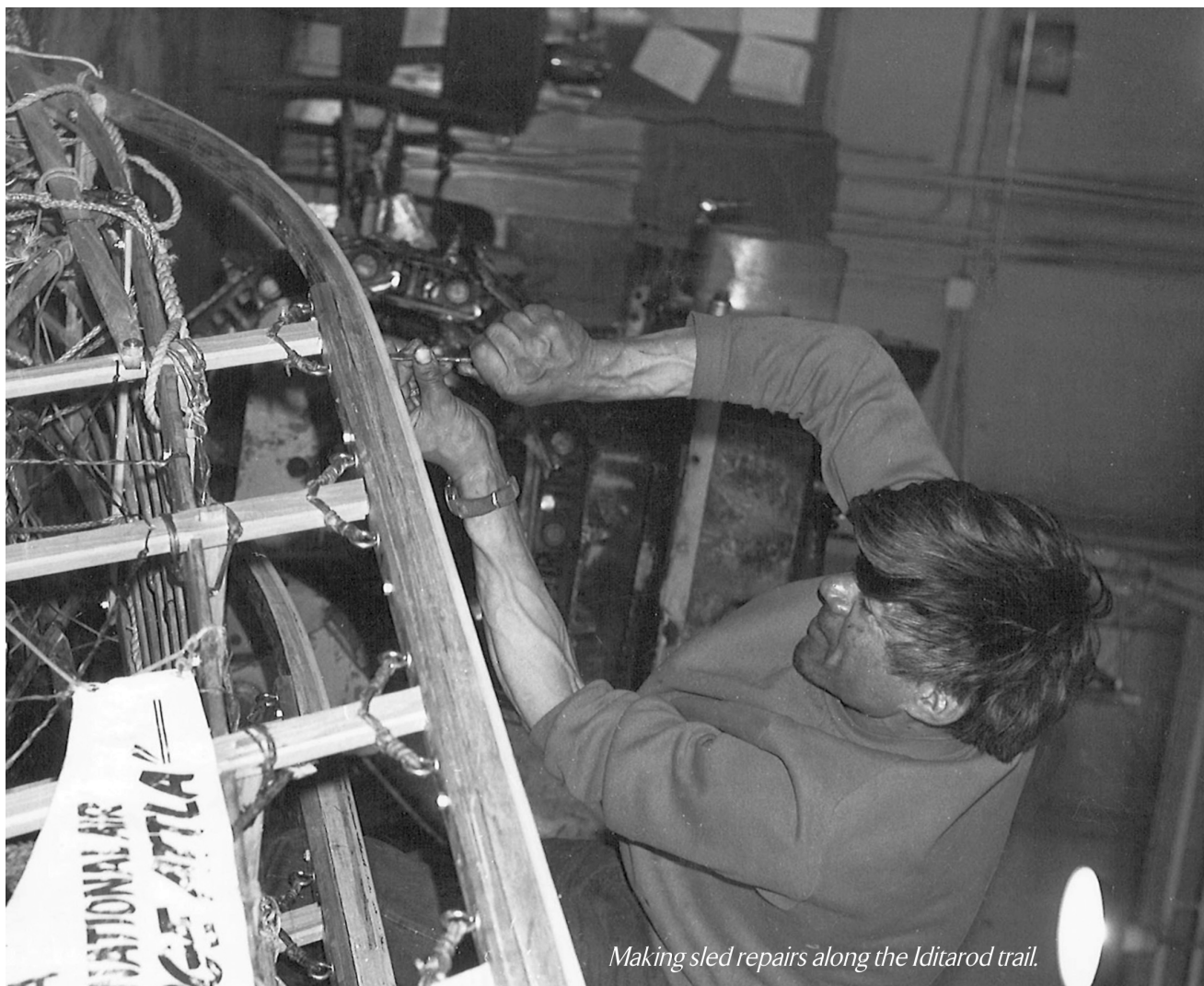
"We didn't know if we'd get there," Attla said of the feeling-it-out atmosphere of the first Iditarod. "I had my own doubts."

Attla's last Rondo title was logged in 1984 and his last North American crown was notched in 1987. Attla remained a viable contender for several more years, until 35 years after his debut.

Attla was well into his 60s when he decided that he would never claim an 11th Rondo world title. He had to let that goal go, but he clung to an ideal that with the passage of time he hoped would become more firmly implanted in the minds of Alaskans.

"I would like to be remembered as the greatest dog musher who ever lived," Attla said. "I think I proved my point."

The combination of Attla's renowned record in the biggest races in his sport and his inspirational overcoming of physical obstacles that would have grounded a lesser man made him a member of the Alaska Sports Hall of Fame's first class.



Making sled repairs along the Iditarod trail.



Talking to fans before the start of the inaugural Iditarod in 1973.